Arsenio A. Quibranza

Arsenio Arcelo Quibranza (1907 – February 28, 1986) was a Filipino educator turned politician who served as the third Governor of Lanao del Norte from 1965 until his term ended on February 28, 1986, making him one of the longest-serving provincial executives in Mindanao's modern history.

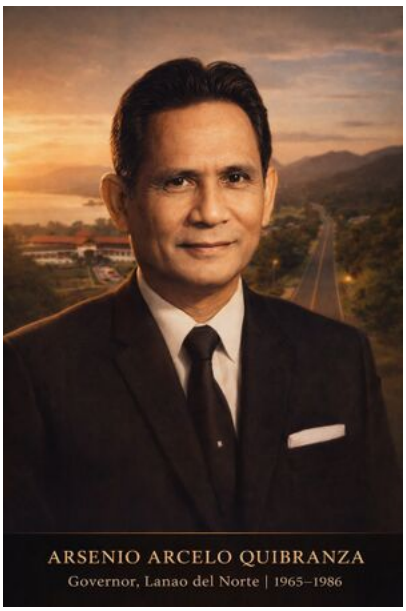
A Christian settler originally from Cebu, Quibranza built his career from the ground up in a predominantly Muslim province, earning the trust of communities across ethnic and religious lines through decades of consistent public service.

He started as a classroom teacher, became the founding mayor of Tubod following the municipality's formal creation in 1949, and eventually rose to lead the entire province through some of its most turbulent decades, including the Ilaga-Barracuda sectarian conflict of the early 1970s and the years of Martial Law under President Ferdinand Marcos.

His name now lives on in three major public institutions in Lanao del Norte: the provincial government center where the province conducts its affairs, a national highway that passes through the heart of Tubod, and a public high school that continues to serve the youth of the capital municipality.

Through his daughter Imelda "Angging" Quibranza-Dimaporo and her children with Governor Abdullah Dimaporo, the Quibranza political legacy remains woven into the fabric of Lanao del Norte's governance to this day.

Arsenio Arcelo Quibranza



Born	1907, Cebu, Philippines
Died	February 28, 1986, Tubod, Lanao del Norte, Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Occupation	Educator, Politician
Political positions	Municipal Mayor of Tubod (1949–1962); Vice Governor of Lanao del Norte (1962–1965); Governor of Lanao del Norte (1965–1986)
Spouse	Teofila dela Cruz
Children	Imelda "Angging" Quibranza-Dimaporo (and others)

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Early Life and Background

Arsenio Arcelo Quibranza was born in 1907 in Cebu, the son of José Quibranza Sr.<ref name="geni">Geni.com. "Arsenio Arcelo Quibranza (1907–1986)." Genealogy profile. Accessed 2025. https://www.geni.com/people/Arsenio-Quibranza/6000000198484291822</ref>

Like many Christian Filipino migrants from the Visayas and Luzon in the early twentieth century, his family settled in Mindanao, eventually making their home in what would become the municipality of Tubod in Lanao del Norte.<ref name="tubodwiki">Wikipedia. "Tubod, Lanao del Norte." https://en.m.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tubod,_Lanao_del_Norte</ref>

He trained and worked as a teacher in his formative years, a background that shaped his lifelong emphasis on education and community service.

The province he eventually came to lead, Lanao del Norte, was itself a young institution. Republic Act No. 2228 divided the old Province of Lanao into two separate provinces in 1959, giving birth to both Lanao del Norte and Lanao del Sur.<ref name="ldnhistory">Provincial Government of Lanao del Norte. "History." https://lanaodelnorte.gov.ph/history/</ref>

Before that division, the region had been a single administrative unit encompassing both the predominantly Christian northern coastal areas and the predominantly Muslim communities around Lake Lanao to the south.

Quibranza grew up and built his career in this complex, multi-ethnic frontier landscape, and it defined him as a politician who had to govern across cultural boundaries from the very beginning.

Early Political Career: Mayor of Tubod

Quibranza's formal entry into politics came through a combination of circumstance and community confidence.

On June 10, 1949, President Elpidio Quirino issued Executive Order No. 222, which created the Municipality of Baroy out of a portion of the then-existing municipal territory. When that order took effect, virtually all of the elected municipal officials in the area opted to transfer their service to the newly created Baroy, leaving the residual municipality of Tubod without a functioning government. Quibranza, who had been serving as a municipal councilor at the time, was the sole elected official who chose to remain.<ref name="tubodwiki"/>

As a result, he was appointed as Municipal Mayor of Tubod effective June 24, 1949, essentially taking charge of a municipality that had just been emptied of its other leaders.<ref name="tubodwiki"/>

That early test of character set the tone for everything that followed. He stepped up when others stepped away.

In the 1951 local elections, he was formally elected as Municipal Mayor of Tubod and subsequently re-elected in both the 1955 and 1959 elections, giving him three consecutive elected terms in addition to his two-year appointed tenure.<ref name="tubodwiki"/>

Over more than a decade as mayor, Quibranza built Tubod from a newly carved-out municipality into a stable local government unit and a community that identified with him personally.

His tenure as mayor ended on March 8, 1962, when President Diosdado Macapagal appointed him as Vice Governor of Lanao del Norte.<ref name="tubodwiki"/>

Vice Governor of Lanao del Norte (1962–1965)

Quibranza's appointment as Vice Governor under President Macapagal came as a recognition of his decade-long track record in Tubod and his standing as a respected Christian political figure in a province whose Muslim-majority areas were increasingly becoming an important part of national political calculations.

He served under Governor Mohammad Ali Dimaporo, a formidable Muslim politician who had risen to become the second Governor of Lanao del Norte following the retirement of the province's first governor, Salvador T. Lluch.<ref name="ldnhistory"/>

The relationship between Quibranza and Ali Dimaporo was, at best, a cautious coexistence between two men who represented different communities, different political networks, and ultimately different ambitions for the province.

In September 1965, Governor Dimaporo ran for and won the congressional seat of Lanao del Norte, vacating the governorship in the process. Under the law of succession, Vice Governor Arsenio Quibranza automatically became the third Provincial Chief Executive of Lanao del Norte.<ref name="ldnhistory"/>

He had arrived at the governorship not through an election but through the workings of political succession, a detail that would add meaning to the strong mandates he received at the ballot box in the years that followed.

Governor of Lanao del Norte (1965–1986)

First Years: Succession and Election

Quibranza took over the governorship in 1965 in the middle of a term, stepping into a role that had been shaped largely by his predecessor's personality and patronage networks.

He had to establish his own authority quickly and demonstrate that he could govern the full breadth of a province that stretched from Panguil Bay in the northwest to the Muslim communities along the periphery of Lanao del Sur in the southeast.

By the mandate of his constituents, Quibranza was elected Governor in 1967 and was almost unanimously re-elected in 1971 and again in 1980, a record of electoral endorsement that few provincial executives in Mindanao could match.<ref name="ldnhistory"/>

The near-unanimous re-elections of 1971 and 1980 are perhaps the clearest measure of the kind of political trust he built over time: a Christian politician winning overwhelming support in a province with a substantial Muslim population, and doing so across multiple election cycles.

The Ilaga-Barracuda Crisis and Political Confrontation

Prior to the declaration of Martial Law in 1972, Mindanao was engulfed in escalating sectarian violence between the Ilaga, a predominantly Christian armed vigilante group, and the Barracuda, which was associated with Moro communities.

In Lanao del Norte, the conflict was particularly intense.

Governor Quibranza and Iligan Mayor Cabili were among those who publicly accused former Governor Mohammad Ali Dimaporo and his brother Naga of providing support to the Barracuda.<ref name="ijijournal">IJRISS. "Between Security and Repressions: The Martial Law Years in Iligan City 1972–1981." https://rsisinternational.org/journals/ijriss/articles/between-security-and-repressions-the-martial-law-years-in-iligan-city-1972-1981/</ref>

The allegations added a layer of political rivalry to what was already a dangerous security situation, and they deepened the already strained relationship between Quibranza and the Dimaporo clan, a tension that would define Lanao del Norte politics for years.

Martial Law, Arrest, and the Actub Interlude

When President Marcos declared Martial Law on September 21, 1972, Quibranza was arrested by order of the president.<ref name="ldnwiki">Wikipedia. "Lanao del Norte." https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Lanao_del_Norte</ref>

The circumstances of his arrest have not been fully documented in the public record, but they were likely connected to the volatile political environment in Lanao del Norte, the ongoing Ilaga-Barracuda violence, and the Marcos administration's broader policy of consolidating control over regional political figures who had their own independent bases of power.

While Quibranza was held in detention, Vice Governor Felix Z. "Toto" Actub succeeded him as Governor of Lanao del Norte.<ref name="ldnwiki"/>

The period of Quibranza's imprisonment remains one of the less documented chapters of his political life. What is clear is that he was eventually released and returned to active political life: he won re-election as Governor in the 1980 elections, resuming his position at the head of the provincial government.

His participation in the political activities surrounding the Interim Batasang Pambansa in 1978 reflects that he navigated the political landscape of the Martial Law years carefully, finding a way to remain a relevant and functioning political actor even in a heavily constrained environment.

Capital Relocation and the Government Center

In 1977, President Marcos signed Resolution No. 805 of the Sangguniang Panlalawigan of Lanao del Norte into Presidential Decree 181, transferring the provincial capital from Iligan City to the municipality of Tubod.<ref name="ldnhistory"/>

The resolution had been sponsored by Assemblyman Abdullah Dimaporo, Ali Dimaporo's son, in an irony of political geography: the son of Quibranza's greatest rival helped engineer the transfer of the provincial capital to the very municipality that Quibranza had built and governed for more than a decade.

In October 1984, inaugural ceremonies were held to mark the transfer of the Provincial Capitol from Poblacion, Tubod, to the Don Mariano Marcos Government Center at Pigcarangan, also in Tubod.<ref name="ldnhistory"/>

That building was later renamed the **Governor Arsenio A. Quibranza Provincial Government Center**, the name by which it is still known today.<ref name="ldngovph">Provincial Government of Lanao del Norte. Official website. https://lanaodelnorte.gov.ph/</ref>

End of Tenure

Quibranza's final year as governor coincided with the political earthquake of February 1986. By virtue of the People Power Revolution at EDSA on February 25, 1986, the Aquino government took over, and local governments across the Philippines were swept into sudden transition.<ref name="ldnhistory"/>

Quibranza's term formally ended on February 28, 1986. Three days later, on March 3, 1986, OIC Atty. Francisco L. Abalos was installed as the appointed governor of Lanao del Norte.<ref name="ldnhistory"/>

Quibranza passed away on February 28, 1986, the same day his tenure officially closed. He did not live to see the full political realignment that followed the restoration of democracy in the Philippines.<ref name="geni"/>

Family and the Quibranza-Dimaporo Political Alliance

Quibranza married Teofila dela Cruz, and together they had a daughter, Imelda, born on January 15, 1959, in Tubod.<ref name="imeldawiki">Wikipedia. "Imelda Dimaporo." https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Imelda_Dimaporo</ref>

In 1977, Imelda married Abdullah "Bobby" Dimaporo, the son of former Governor Mohammad Ali Dimaporo, in a dual civil and Islamic ceremony.<ref name="imeldawiki"/>

The marriage was remarkable precisely because it united two families who had been political rivals. The Quibranza and Dimaporo clans had spent years on opposite sides of provincial politics, with the elder Ali Dimaporo representing the Muslim political establishment and Arsenio Quibranza representing the Christian settler community. Imelda's marriage to Abdullah effectively created a cross-community political alliance that would prove enormously durable.

The union produced five children. Two of them, Mohamad Khalid Quibranza Dimaporo and Sittie Aminah Quibranza Dimaporo, went on to hold significant legislative and executive positions in Lanao del Norte, continuing the family's governing role into the twenty-first century.<ref name="ldngovph"/>

Imelda Quibranza-Dimaporo

Imelda "Angging" Quibranza-Dimaporo studied Business Administration at the Philippine Women's University and built a political career on the combined legacy of both her father and her husband's family.<ref name="imeldawiki"/>

She was elected Governor of Lanao del Norte in the 1998 elections and served until 2007. She returned to the governorship in 2016 and served until 2025, during which time the province received the Seal of Good Local Governance from the Department of the Interior and Local Government.<ref name="sglg">Provincial Government of Lanao del Norte. "Lanao del Norte Bags Seal of Good Local Governance Award." https://lanaodelnorte.gov.ph/lanao-del-norte-bags-seal-of-good-local-governance-award/</ref>

She also served as the Representative for Lanao del Norte's 1st District, from 2010 to 2016 and again from 2025 onward.<ref name="imeldawiki"/>

Legacy and Honors

The Arsenio Arcelo Quibranza Highway

In 2018, the Philippine Congress enacted Republic Act No. 11051, naming the Poblacion-Caniogan National Road, which traverses Barangays Poblacion, San Antonio, Patudan, Pinpin, Mabngao, Licapao, Candis, Caniogan, and Barakanas in the Municipality of Tubod, as the **Arsenio Arcelo Quibranza Highway**.<ref name="ra11051">The Corpus Juris. "R.A. No. 11051: An Act Naming the Poblacion-Caniogan National Road Traversing Barangay Poblacion and Barangay Barakanas in the Municipality of Tubod, Province of Lanao del Norte as the Arsenio Arcelo Quibranza Highway." https://thecorpusjuris.com/legislative/republic-acts/ra-no-11051.php</ref>

The bill had passed the House of Representatives on May 29, 2017, and was approved by the Senate on March 12, 2018.<ref name="ra11051"/>

The highway naming was proposed with the support of the Dimaporo family's legislative bloc, a gesture that underscored how thoroughly the political alliance forged through Imelda's marriage had redefined the old Quibranza-Dimaporo rivalry into a shared political inheritance.

The Provincial Government Center

The **Governor Arsenio A. Quibranza Provincial Government Center** at Pigcarangan, Tubod, serves as the official seat of the Lanao del Norte provincial government. The complex, originally opened in October 1984 as the Don Mariano Marcos Government Center, was renamed in Quibranza's honor following his death, recognizing his role as the longest-serving governor and the chief executive during whose administration the capital transfer was completed.<ref name="ldnhistory"/>

Arsenio A. Quibranza National High School

The **Arsenio A. Quibranza National High School** in Tubod, Lanao del Norte, bears his name in recognition of his background as an educator and his advocacy for access to public education during his years in office. The school continues to serve secondary-level students in the provincial capital.

A Legacy Carried Forward

Quibranza's most enduring legacy may not be any single institution but the political dynasty he helped create: a family network that bridged the Christian-Muslim divide in Lanao del Norte at a time when sectarian tensions made that kind of bridge-building genuinely dangerous.

He was a Visayan Christian who earned the trust of a predominantly Muslim electorate, held his ground during Martial Law even at the cost of his personal freedom, and left behind a family that continues to govern the province he shaped.

> *"By the mandate of the inhabitants, Governor Quibranza was elected Governor in 1967 and almost unanimously re-elected in 1971 and again in 1980."* (Provincial Government of Lanao del Norte, Official History)

That near-unanimity across ethnically diverse communities says more about the man than any list of accomplishments could.

Challenges and Controversies

Quibranza's tenure was not without its complexities. The accusations he leveled against the Dimaporo brothers over alleged support for the Barracuda were politically charged and contributed to the climate of distrust that preceded Martial Law in Lanao del Norte.<ref name="ijijournal"/>

His arrest under Marcos remains only partially documented, and the full circumstances behind it, including how long he was held and under what conditions, are not part of any accessible official record.

The coexistence of his governorship with the operations of both Ilaga and Barracuda groups in the province also raises questions about the limits of what he was able to accomplish in terms of protecting civilian communities from sectarian violence, a challenge that confronted every provincial executive in Mindanao during the early 1970s.

Historians studying the Martial Law period in Iligan and the surrounding region note that the overall security framework of the time relied heavily on military intervention, and that local civilian executives like Quibranza had limited independent capacity to manage the conflict once the Armed Forces of the Philippines took a central role.<ref name="ijijournal"/>

Death

Arsenio Arcelo Quibranza died on February 28, 1986, in Tubod, Lanao del Norte, the municipality he had served as founding mayor and the capital of the province he governed for more than two decades.<ref name="geni"/>

His death came on the same day his gubernatorial tenure formally ended, as the People Power Revolution swept local government leadership across the Philippines into transition.

He was survived by his wife Teofila dela Cruz Quibranza and their daughter Imelda "Angging" Quibranza-Dimaporo, as well as his grandchildren and the extended family network that continued his political legacy in the years that followed.

Further Reading

- Provincial Government of Lanao del Norte. "History of Lanao del Norte." https://lanaodelnorte.gov.ph/history/
- Wikipedia. "Lanao del Norte." https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Lanao_del_Norte
- Wikipedia. "Imelda Dimaporo." https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Imelda_Dimaporo
- Wikipedia. "Tubod, Lanao del Norte." https://en.m.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tubod,_Lanao_del_Norte
- The Corpus Juris. "Republic Act No. 11051." https://thecorpusjuris.com/legislative/republic-acts/ra-no-11051.php
- IJRISS. "Between Security and Repressions: The Martial Law Years in Iligan City 1972–1981." https://rsisinternational.org/journals/ijriss/articles/between-security-and-repressions-the-martial-law-years-in-iligan-city-1972-1981/

See Also

- Lanao del Norte
- Tubod, Lanao del Norte
- Imelda Dimaporo
- Mohammad Ali Dimaporo
- Abdullah Dimaporo
- Mohamad Khalid Quibranza Dimaporo
- Governor of Lanao del Norte
- Martial Law in the Philippines
- Bangsamoro

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